



# A Smarter (More Efficient) Way to Onboard New Members

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The background of the top section is a blurred image of a person's hands using a laptop. Overlaid on this are several glowing, semi-transparent icons: a cloud with up and down arrows, a database cylinder, a smartphone, a person icon, and a house icon, all connected by a network of lines.

## How associations are using AI-powered engagement to build first-year relationships that last

Many associations invest significant time and budget into acquiring new members. Fewer associations invest the same level of intention into what happens once someone joins. Yet those first few months shape how a member experiences the organization for years to come.

New members join with real intent. They want to learn, connect, grow, and get value from your association. But after the welcome email arrives and the login credentials are sent, many are left to navigate everything on their own. They aren't sure where to start, who to talk to, or what matters most. From the association's side, it's just as unclear. Staff can see names in a database, but they don't know who is engaged, who is confused, or who is already starting to drift away.

That gap (the one between joining and belonging) is where first-year churn begins.

## Why traditional onboarding doesn't hold up

Most onboarding programs are built around pushing information out. New members get a sequence of emails, links to all of resources (read: every. single. resource.), invitations to events, and maybe a welcome webinar. All of that is helpful, but it assumes people will sort through it, figure out what's relevant, and raise their hand if they need support.

In reality, that rarely happens. People skim, postpone, and move on (or flat out forget). They may not be unhappy, but they also never build enough clarity or connection to feel invested. When renewal time comes, it's easy to let membership quietly lapse.

**So what's missing here?** It's not more content **FOR** the new member, it's feedback **FROM** the new member. Without an easy way to learn what new members are looking for, where they are in their careers, or how they want to engage, onboarding becomes generic. And generic experiences are oftentimes easy to walk away from.

# How AI Changes What's Possible

For years, associations have had to choose between two relatively imperfect options: keep onboarding simple and generic, or make it thoughtful and personalized but completely manual. The kind of responsive experience members expect today simply took too much time to run at scale.

## AI CHANGES THAT.



Today, AI can recognize patterns across thousands of interactions, turn best practices into repeatable structures, and automate the logic that used to live in spreadsheets and staff members' heads. It can help decide what to ask, when to ask it, and what should happen when someone responds. That's how onboarding can feel human without requiring humans to manage every step.

For example – PropFuel supports this approach by making it quick and easy to run conversational email campaigns that capture member responses and turn them into usable insight. One of the ways it does this is through something called Blueprints.

A Blueprint is an AI-generated campaign framework built from what has worked across hundreds of associations. When you run a blueprint, PropFuel creates a complete onboarding flow in minutes (yes, truly, just minutes!!) including the emails, the questions, the branching logic, and the actions that happen behind the scenes.

Your team then reviews what was created. You can adjust the wording, remove or add questions, and decide which responses should update your AMS or trigger follow-up. The structure is already there. Once it looks right, it can be tested and set live.

The value is not complexity. It is speed. Blueprints make it easier to go from “we should improve onboarding” to a working program that is actually engaging members.



# A Practical Onboarding Flow You Can Use

## 1 START BY UNDERSTANDING INTENT

Shortly after someone joins, ask a single question: **What are you most hoping to get out of your membership this year?**

- Career growth
- Networking
- Education or credentials
- Advocacy
- Something else

This single answer tells you why the person joined and helps guide what you share next.

## 2 ADD CONTEXT ABOUT WHERE THEY ARE

One or two weeks later, ask: **How would you describe your current career stage?**

- Student
- Early career
- Mid-career
- Senior or executive
- Retired

This helps the organization understand how that intent fits into the member's professional journey.

## 3 CHECK FOR EARLY VALUE

A few weeks later, ask: **Are you getting the right information from us?**

- Yes
- No

This gives you an early signal about whether the onboarding experience is working and members are receiving value.

## 4 START LEARNING ABOUT PREFERENCES

As you continue the onboarding process, start **asking questions that help you learn more about member preferences**, such as:

- How do you prefer to be contacted?
- How would you like to engage with the association?
- How do you prefer to network?

Even this small amount of structured listening gives an association far more insight into new members than most traditional onboarding programs ever capture.

The title "Onboarding" is centered within a white, irregularly shaped hole torn into a piece of brown cardboard. The cardboard has a rough, fibrous texture. In the top left and bottom right corners of the overall image, there are faint, concentric orange circles.

# Onboarding

## Why this Approach Works

None of these questions are complicated. What makes them powerful is that they are asked over time, tied to real action, and supported by AI behind the scenes.

This is what modern onboarding looks like: a living, responsive system that helps new members feel known and helps associations protect their most vulnerable year.

Whether an association uses PropFuel or another platform, the principle is the same. When onboarding becomes a conversation instead of a broadcast, first-year retention stops being a gamble and starts becoming something you can actually manage.

# The 90-Day Onboarding Map



| Week       | What to Ask                                                                          | Why It Matters                                                          | What you can do with the answer                                                                   |
|------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Week 1     | What motivated you to join right now?                                                | Reveals the primary driver behind the membership decision               | Align the first set of resources, events, and recommendations to what they actually care about    |
| Week 2     | Where are you in your career?                                                        | Adds context to their goals and helps avoid one-size-fits-all messaging | Segment early-career members toward learning and senior members toward leadership or advocacy     |
| Week 3     | What is your biggest professional challenge right now?                               | Surfaces real pain points that generic onboarding never captures        | Route members to relevant content, communities, or staff                                          |
| Week 5     | Are you getting what you expected from your membership so far?                       | Acts as an early indicator of satisfaction or risk                      | Trigger outreach for anyone who answers "not yet"                                                 |
| Week 7     | On a scale of 0–10, how likely are you to recommend this association to a colleague? | Establishes a baseline NPS early in the lifecycle                       | Identify promoters, passives, and at-risk members while there is time to influence the experience |
| Week 9     | Do you see yourself renewing when your term is up?                                   | Surfaces renewal intent months before a formal renewal cycle            | Prioritize follow-up with anyone who is unsure or leaning no                                      |
| Week 11–12 | How do you prefer to engage with us going forward?                                   | Helps prevent over-communication and disengagement                      | Optimize channel mix, cadence, and types of outreach                                              |

This structure gives you a rolling view of how new members are feeling, not just at renewal time but while there is still room to improve the relationship.

# HOW TO USE THIS, Even If You Change Nothing Else



Choose three to five of these questions and place them deliberately across the first ninety days. Make sure the answers go somewhere visible and that someone on your team is responsible for acting on them.



Even modest changes in how early feedback is collected and used can dramatically improve how supported new members feel.



For teams using PropFuel, this entire map can be implemented quickly using Blueprints. For everyone else, it provides a practical way to rethink how onboarding should work.

## Bringing it all together

The first year of membership is when people decide whether your association truly fits into their professional lives. When onboarding is built only around delivering information, that decision is left largely to chance. When it is built around listening and responding, it becomes something you can actively shape.

The most effective programs are not defined by how much content they send, but by how well they understand new members early on. Whether through PropFuel or other tools, the principle is the same: when you know what your members need in their first ninety days, you are far better equipped to support them for years to come.

